

Precarious Sexuality

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Precarious Sexuality: How Men and Women Are Differentially Categorized for Similar Sexual Behavior

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Abstract

Are men and women categorized differently for similar sexual behavior? Building on theories of gender, sexuality, and status, we introduce the concept of *precarious sexuality* to suggest that men's—but not women's—heterosexuality is an especially privileged identity that is easily lost. We test our hypotheses in a series of survey experiments describing a person who has a sexual experience conflicting with their sexual history. We find that a single same-sex sexual encounter leads an observer to question a heterosexual man's sexual orientation to a greater extent than that of a heterosexual woman in a similar situation. We also find that a different-sex sexual encounter is more likely to change others' perceptions of a lesbian woman's sexual orientation—compared to perceptions of a gay man's sexual orientation. In two conceptual replications, we vary the level of intimacy of the sexual encounter and find consistent evidence for our idea of precarious sexuality for heterosexual men. We close with a general discussion of how status beliefs influence categorization processes and with suggestions for extending our theoretical propositions to other categories beyond those of sexual orientation.

Keywords

gender, sexuality, social psychology, status, stigma

Are men and women categorized differently by others even when displaying similar sexual behavior? Perceptions of sexual orientation are important because individuals who are viewed as gay, lesbian, or bisexual face broadly unfavorable sentiments and a wide range of societal disadvantages (Herek 2002, 2009; Lax and Phillips 2009; Mishel 2016; Powell, Quadlin, and Pizmony-Levy 2015; Tilcsik 2011). We contribute to the literature on gender, sexual orientation, and status by examining how men and women are differentially categorized based on similar sexual

behavior. We advance current understandings of these processes by providing evidence of differential sexual orientation categorization for men and women.

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We argue that interpretations of others' sexual behavior stem from status beliefs attached to sexual orientation categories. These conceptions are themselves partially a product of beliefs about sexual orientation and gender. We propose that status differences cause observers to differentially categorize men and women who exhibit similar behavior. We suggest that men's (but not women's) heterosexuality is therefore a *precarious sexuality*: an identity whose boundaries are clearly drawn and heavily policed, and thus an identity that is easily lost and must constantly be protected. Specifically, we propose that any same-sex sexual behavior exhibited by a man will cause others to no longer consider him to be heterosexual. We suggest this occurs because of the highly discrepant status distinctions among men's sexual orientation categories. In contrast, we suggest women's sexual orientation groups have relatively less status differentiation. Women's heterosexuality offers fewer relative status advantages than does men's heterosexuality. For women, the boundaries for belonging to different sexual orientation categories are more fluid, and women's heterosexuality is therefore less precarious.

Despite increasing public attention to sexual minority issues, relatively little sociological or social psychological work has examined how sexual orientation influences social outcomes (Hunt et al. 2013).¹ We draw on theories of status, gender, and sexuality to develop predictions about how categorization processes operate differently for men and women who engage in similar sexual behavior. Using a series of vignette-based survey experiments, we provide evidence that men and women are differentially categorized for similar sexual behavior. In our first empirical test, we use a nationally representative sample of adults in the United States to examine how a single casual sexual encounter causes individuals to categorize men and women differently. Finally, in two follow-up studies we investigate whether differences in categorization are due to assumed differences in the sexual behavior of men and women in same-sex encounters.

THEORETICAL BACKGROUND

Our goal in this article is to understand how individuals categorize others' sexual orientation based on knowledge of their sexual behavior. We examine situations where a person's sexual behavior leads to an ambiguous signal of their sexual orientation. We focus on how similar behavior has different consequences for how men and women are categorized. Examining perceptions of sexual orientation is important, as individuals can only face direct stigmatization and discrimination from others if someone places them into a disadvantaged category. Sexual minorities interact with other individuals frequently, but only rarely will a person explicitly reveal their sexual orientation. Individuals with whom they interact, however, are likely to place them into a sexual orientation category. Sexual orientation, like gender and race, are social categories that are often automatically perceived and categorized by others with whom we interact (Ridgeway 2011; Rule et al. 2008; Rule, Ambady, and Hallett 2009).²

Being classified as a sexual minority can carry a range of disadvantages, many stemming from discrimination and stigmatization (Herek, Gillis, and Cogan 2009; Herek and McLemore 2013; Mishel 2016; Tilcsik 2011). For example, Herek and colleagues (Herek 2002; Herek and McLemore 2013) show that sexual minorities are viewed less favorably than most religious and ethnic groups; Powell and colleagues (2010, 2015) find many individuals still report moral disapproval of same-sex couples; Tilcsik (2011) and Mishel (2016) report causal evidence of hiring discrimination against sexual minorities; and Doan, Loehr, and Miller (2014) find that individuals continue to report high levels of subtle prejudice, such as discomfort with same-sex affection. Moreover, levels of sexual minority prejudice are likely understated due to increasing social desirability bias when measuring attitudes about sexual minorities (Coffman, Coffman, and Ericson 2016). Despite changing attitudes, sexual minorities can still face damaging and negative views if others classify them as non-heterosexual.

We suggest that sexual orientation categorization depends primarily on the status beliefs associated with sexual orientation categories. We first discuss work on status beliefs. We draw on research on race and masculinity to theorize how categorization processes are influenced by social status. We propose that a general precarious status dynamic can account for similar phenomena influencing categorization for racial, gender, and sexual orientation groups. Finally, we extend our idea of precarious statuses to sexuality, predicting that heterosexual men's sexuality is particularly precarious.

Social Status and Precarious Identities

We argue that men and women face differential reactions to similar sexual behavior because of status beliefs attached to sexual orientation categories. Before outlining the specific implications for sexual orientation, we provide an overview of theory on status generally and develop the idea of precarious statuses. By *status*, we are referring to the differential respect and esteem given to individual members of a group based on culturally shared ideas about a group's social position and place in a social hierarchy (Podolny 2005; Ridgeway and Correll 2004; Sharkey 2014). Certain groups are afforded higher levels of respect and esteem than others. Importantly, these social categories influence how the behavior of a member of that social category is viewed (Foschi 2000; Sharkey 2014). In general, high-status individuals are more likely to have their ideas solicited, listened to, and praised, compared to their lower-status counterparts (Correll and Ridgeway 2003). Past work shows that men are treated as higher status than women and that whites are treated as higher status than racial minorities (for overviews, see Berger and Webster 2006; Correll and Ridgeway 2003). Gender and race are clear examples of status characteristics, but any social designation—such as sexual orientation—should carry the ability to acquire status value (Johnson 1995;

Ridgeway 2006; Ridgeway et al. 1998; Webster, Hysom, and Fullmer 1998).

By definition, high-status groups hold privileged and advantageous places in the social hierarchy. However, we argue that membership in these high-status social groups may also be precarious. By *precarious*, we mean that the boundaries protecting membership in the category are heavily policed, and thus membership in the category is easily lost. The history of racial categorization in the United States provides one example. In the United States, white is—and historically has been—the high-status racial category. The “one-drop rule”—which asserted that individuals with even one ancestor from sub-Saharan Africa (i.e., “one drop” of black blood) are classified as non-white—is an illustration of how membership in advantageous social categories (e.g., whiteness in the United States) is heavily policed (Khanna 2010; Lee and Bean 2004). Even a minimal amount of category-inconsistent racial or ethnic information is enough to be barred from membership in the high-status category. By systematically removing individuals with associations of low status (e.g., mixed-race individuals) from the high-status category (white), the one-drop rule helped maintain “white” as the privileged and advantaged high-status designation (Douglas 1966).

Similar to whiteness, men's masculinity is also a high-status and precarious identity. Although many different masculinities exist, and expectations for men's behavior can vary across contexts, the stereotypical ideal of masculinity in a given culture is hegemonic masculinity. Hegemonic masculinity emphasizes men's dominant societal position and includes strict guidelines for what constitutes appropriate behavior (Connell 1995; Connell and Messerschmidt 2005). Men are motivated to fulfill these expectations, because masculine men are afforded many social advantages (Schrock and Schwalbe 2009).

However, like whiteness, hegemonic masculinity is an especially precarious identity that can be easily lost. Men who display feminine behavior encounter penalties and backlash

from others. They thus face the possibility of being stripped of their masculine identity and the benefits it affords (Moss-Racusin, Phelan, and Rudman 2010; Rudman et al. 2012; Vandello et al. 2008). Because of this, men are pressured to act in ways that protect the status of the masculine identity (Brescoll et al. 2012; Pascoe 2007; Vandello et al. 2008). To protect the status of masculinity as an advantaged state, men police each other's masculinity—criticizing the behavior of other men they view as insufficiently masculine (Pascoe 2007). To protect their own masculinity, the majority of men are acutely sensitive to even minor threats to their masculinity and respond in ways meant to correct perceptions of insufficient masculinity (Schrock and Schwalbe 2009; Vandello et al. 2008; Willer et al. 2013). Because of both the strict guidelines for what qualifies as hegemonically masculine behavior and the heavy policing of the identity, the high-status designation of men's masculinity is preserved.

A General Framework of Precarious Statuses

As the above examples of race and masculinity suggest, categorization is a product of two factors: the status beliefs about the group an individual currently belongs to, and the status of the group that any category-inconsistent behavior or information suggests (Phillips, Turco, and Zuckerman 2013; Podolny 2005). Our argument is that individuals in high-status groups (e.g., whites, masculine men, heterosexual men) are in the most precarious position. Members of high-status groups will be most likely to be recategorized as a result of category-inconsistent behavior compared to lower-status individuals. This recategorization occurs when any category-inconsistent behavior/information suggests a lower-status category designation (e.g., racial minority, femininity, sexual minority), as low-status behavior threatens perceived membership in the high-status group. In this way, the "purity" and high social standing of the category is preserved by purging individuals who exhibit category-inconsistent—and lower-status—behavior (Douglas 1966). In contrast, category-inconsistent behavior from

individuals in a lower-status group (e.g., racial minorities, feminine men, heterosexual women) is less likely to threaten their perceived membership in that social group, because there is less motivation to protect that group's status standing.

An important scope condition for our argument is that categorization is limited to plausible alternative identities and group memberships. That is, some identities and group memberships are unavailable for certain individuals. For various reasons, certain identities may be viewed as innate or immutable, whereas others can be viewed as more malleable. For example, "masculine white man" is an unlikely alternative identity for someone who was previously classified as a "masculine black man" and has dark skin (especially under a U.S.-style "one drop rule" racial categorization system). The categories of "feminine black man" and "gay black man," however, are plausible categories to which someone who is initially viewed as a "masculine black man" may be recategorized. This is because gendered behavior (i.e., masculinity and femininity) and sexual orientation are widely recognized as identities that can change over time for some individuals (at least in the eyes of American observers). Other categories, in contrast, are largely viewed as immutable by the average American. Therefore, status dynamics are likely to affect categorization only to the extent that plausible alternative group memberships and identities exist in the eyes of observers.

Sexual Orientation, Status Beliefs, and the Precariousness of Men's Heterosexuality

How might the dynamics of precarious statuses influence sexual orientation categorization? First, it is important to note that the concept of sexual orientation encompasses at least three dimensions: *behavior*, *identity*, and *attraction*. *Sexual behavior* can indicate orientation based on the gender category of someone's sexual partners; individuals can *identify* themselves as a certain orientation based on what they believe best describes

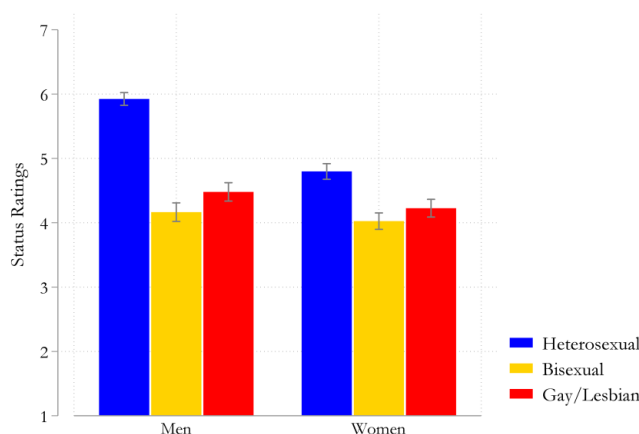


Figure 1. Perceptions of Social Status of Sexual Orientation Groups (Mize and Manago forthcoming)

them. Whether a person is romantically *attracted* to men, women, both, or neither can also indicate sexual orientation (Laumann et al. 1994; Mize 2015). Our interest in this article is how *others* interpret a person's sexual behavior—specifically, what identity they ascribe individuals based on knowledge of their sexual behavior.

We argue that sexual orientation categorization is a substantively important example of the general precarious status phenomenon we outlined earlier, operating similarly to how status dynamics affect the categorization of racial identity and masculinity. This similarity should exist because knowledge of a person's gender and sexual orientation comes with important status implications. This is due to a combination of (1) widely known differences in social standing between sexual orientation groups, (2) normativity beliefs related to sexual practices, and (3) beliefs about masculinity and femininity.³ These factors combine to give observers an idea of others' overall status standing based on their gender and sexual orientation.

In general, most Americans view heterosexuality as normative and as more highly valued than non-heterosexual orientations (Johnson 1995; Mize and Manago forthcoming; Rubin 1984). Heterosexual men and women also receive broad social benefits, as they do not face social and moral disapproval

or limitations to their legal rights in the same way sexual minorities do (Herek and McLemore 2013; Human Rights Campaign 2018). However, ideas about masculinity and femininity further complicate the status connotations of sexual orientation categories, leading to important intersectional considerations.

Figure 1 comes from recent experimental work on stereotypes of sexual orientation; it plots perceptions of social status for different sexual orientation groups (from Mize and Manago forthcoming).⁴ Heterosexual men hold notably higher social status than bisexual or gay men and all women (see Figure 1). These perceptions of social status have important real-world correlates: gay and bisexual men face less social approval, encounter disadvantaging assumptions about their competence and capability, and report worse health and labor market outcomes (Gorman et al. 2015; Herek 2002; Mize 2016; Tilcsik 2011).

Perceptions of social status have multiple sources—including perceptions of masculinity and femininity. Masculinity provides status advantages for men: individuals viewed as masculine are assumed to be more competent and capable than individuals who are viewed as feminine (Johnson 1995; Mize 2017; Mize and Manago forthcoming). Part of satisfying masculine expectations for men—and thus receiving full status advantages—is to be *attracted* to and sexually interested in women (Connell

1995; Pascoe 2007; Schrock and Schwalbe 2009). By definition, gay men are not attracted to women and thus do not satisfy masculine expectations about desiring women (Mize 2015; Worthen 2013). Culturally, a bisexual identity for men does not appear to satisfy this requirement either, as many individuals stereotype bisexual men as “actually gay,” that is, not sexually interested in women (Dodge, Reece, and Gebhard 2008; Mize and Manago forthcoming; Yost and Thomas 2012). Thus, for both gay and bisexual men, a combination of stereotypes about being less masculine and less normative than heterosexual men, along with myriad social disadvantages, leads to broad perceptions of gay and bisexual men as having lower social status than heterosexual men (see Figure 1).

In contrast to the clear status distinctions among sexual orientation categories for men, women’s sexual orientation categories engender relatively more equality in terms of status beliefs (see right half of Figure 1). For women, all sexual orientation categories carry lower perceptions of social status than that afforded heterosexual men; however, there is much less differentiation *among* sexual orientation categories for women. In terms of real-world correlates, lesbian women face no competence penalties compared to heterosexual women and, in terms of labor market compensation, they generally earn equivalent or higher wages than heterosexual women (Klawitter 2014; Mize 2016, 2017; Peplau and Fingerhut 2004). Bisexual women, however, do have worse health and labor market outcomes than heterosexual women (Gorman et al. 2015; Mize 2016). However, as Figure 1 shows, these factors appear to lead to only mild disadvantages in terms of perceptions of social status for bisexual women relative to heterosexual women.

Why is there less status differentiation among women’s sexual orientation categories? In contrast to expectations for men, part of satisfying feminine expectations for women—and thus living up to the cultural ideal of being a woman—is to be *attractive to* and available to men (Connell 1987; Jackson

and Scott 2010). Unlike for men, same-sex behavior for women—although falling outside of heterosexual expectations—does not undermine expectations for femininity, because it does not necessarily decrease women’s attractiveness to men. In some cases, women’s same-sex behavior can be seen as “sexy” or enticing to men, thus enhancing their attractiveness to men, and simultaneously helping satisfy expectations for femininity (Pascoe 2007; Rupp and Taylor 2010; Yost and Thomas 2012).

In terms of status—and in contrast to the effect for men—it is unclear that gender non-normativity (e.g., masculine behavior) is associated with status loss for women. As Pascoe (2007:120) notes in her ethnographical account of gender and sexuality in high school: “Unlike gender and sexual non-normativity for boys, which decrease a boy’s social status, gender and sexual non-normativity for girls can actually increase their social status.” Because same-sex behavior does not necessarily conflict with satisfying expectations for femininity, and because gender non-normativity does not always decrease a woman’s social standing, there are less clear status penalties for lesbian and bisexual women compared to heterosexual women (as Figure 1 suggests). We are not arguing that a certain sexual orientation group for women has higher status. Instead, the key point is that all women’s sexual orientation categories are *relatively undifferentiated*, with no category having the clear and dramatic status advantage that heterosexual has among men’s sexual orientation categories.

Hypotheses

In summary, there are larger status distinctions among men’s sexual orientation groups than among women’s sexual orientation groups, with heterosexual men holding an especially unique and high-status position relative to gay and bisexual men, and all women. Because of heterosexual men’s particularly high status, we predict that men’s heterosexuality will be the most heavily

policed sexual orientation identity, with small deviations from heterosexual behavior causing men to no longer be viewed as heterosexual by others. In contrast, because no sexual orientation category for women is markedly differentiated in terms of high status value, we suggest there is less policing of the boundaries of each category. As such, a single incongruous sexual encounter should prove less pivotal for assumptions of a woman's heterosexual orientation. That is, a single same-sex experience should not threaten a woman's heterosexual status position to the extent that a same-sex experience will threaten a man's heterosexual status position:

Hypothesis 1: A man with a heterosexual history who exhibits same-sex attraction or behavior will be considered non-heterosexual at higher rates compared to a woman with a heterosexual history who exhibits same-sex attraction or behavior.

It is less clear how category-inconsistent behavior will affect individuals with histories of same-sex behavior. Nevertheless, examining category-inconsistent behavior among people with histories of gay/lesbian relationships can shed light on the status dynamics surrounding heterosexual orientations. That is, beliefs about the status of men's and women's heterosexuality should also influence categorization of gay men and lesbian women who have a different-sex experience. The strict boundaries for category membership that make men's heterosexuality precarious should influence not only individuals' perceived lack of membership in the category but also their ability to be perceived as members of the category. Part of protecting the high status of men's heterosexuality should be preventing lower-status individuals from entering into the category, which would threaten its hegemonic position. As such, it is unlikely that a man with a history of same-sex relationships who engages in heterosexual behavior would be allowed to enter the high-status category of a heterosexual identity.

In contrast, because there is less status differentiation among women's sexual orientations, there should be more flexibility in

moving among these categories, with entrance into and out of different categories being less heavily guarded. Indeed, women's sexuality is generally seen as more malleable and fluid than men's sexuality (Baumeister 2000; Diamond 2003; Peplau 2003). Therefore, a woman with a same-sex dating history who has a different-sex experience may experience more fluidity in categorizations of her sexual orientation. Entrance into other female sexual orientation categories (e.g., heterosexual or bisexual) is unlikely to be policed to the same extent as men's sexuality.

Hypothesis 2: A man with a same-sex sexual history who exhibits heterosexual attraction or behavior will be considered heterosexual less often than a woman with a same-sex history who exhibits heterosexual attraction or behavior.

High-Status Leniency: A Counterargument

Thus far, we have focused on how status dynamics make high-status designations precarious. However, previous research suggests an alternative possibility. In particular, there is evidence that higher-status actors are given more leniency than lower-status actors in how they are evaluated. Foschi's (2000) double standards theory, for example, suggests that higher-status individuals (e.g., men) are held to more lenient standards than are lower-status individuals (e.g., women). In regard to the present study, this suggests that heterosexual men's behavior might be judged more leniently, with less impact on assumptions of their sexual orientation, than the behavior of someone from a lower-status group, such as heterosexual women. It is important to note that double standards theory applies to *evaluations* of a person's behavior and has not been extended to *categorization* of a person into a social group—thus, it is unclear whether we should expect the theory to extend to the process of sexual orientation categorization.

Another similar counterargument comes from work on organizations. Multiple studies show that high-status actors have more

leniency in their actions because their place in the status structure is more secure, whereas middle-status actors are most cognizant of avoiding delegitimizing behavior because it poses more of a threat to their status position (Durand and Kremp 2016; Phillips and Zuckerman 2001; Podolny 2005; Sharkey 2014). However, Phillips and Zuckerman (2001:420) also note that this pattern should only hold “where an action poses a threat of delegitimation, but not so threatening that even high-status actors are made to feel insecure.” That is, actions that are seen as slightly lower status are allowed without threatening high-status actors’ position, whereas actions that are “more deeply discrediting” do threaten their position and should be avoided (Phillips and Zuckerman 2001:420).⁵ It is possible that some minor behavior from heterosexual men suggesting category-inconsistency (e.g., kissing another man) would not threaten their category membership, but more explicit behaviors (e.g., having a sexual encounter with another man) would reach the threshold to threaten their category membership. We consider both situations in our empirical assessment of sexual orientation categorization.

Overview of the Studies

In the following sections, we present two survey experiments testing how individuals categorize others based on their sexual behavior. We use experimental designs to identify the causal effect of past relationship history on assessments of sexual orientation for both men and women. In particular, we examine whether men’s heterosexuality is more easily questioned and lost compared to women’s heterosexuality. By taking an experimental approach we are able to determine whether—given the same romantic situation—a person’s gender influences assumptions of their sexual orientation, independent of any other factors.

Study 1, conducted in a nationally representative sample of the U.S. population, uses vignettes to describe a vague casual sexual encounter.⁶ Participants categorize the

vignette character’s sexual orientation. The purpose of this study is to examine whether even a minimal amount of sexual contact leads to differences in categorization for men and women. In a follow-up study (2A and 2B), we examine specific sexual behaviors and vary the level of intimacy described in the vignette to determine whether differences in categorizations are due to differences in assumed sexual behavior between men and women in same-sex sexual encounters.

STUDY 1

Study 1 was conducted as an online survey experiment on a nationally representative panel. Data were collected by GfK with support from Time-Sharing Experiments for the Social Sciences (TESS) (Freese and Druckman 2015). A total of 2,035 participants were randomly selected from the GfK panel, which recruits participants via a combination of random-digit dialing and address-based sampling methods to ensure representativeness of the adult U.S. population.

Methods

To determine how others differentially categorize the sexual behavior of men versus women in a way consistent with the concept of precarious sexuality, we designed a vignette study. We describe an individual with a history of exclusively heterosexual or gay/lesbian relationships who has recently had a sexual encounter discrepant with their relationship history. Participants are then asked to categorize the sexual orientation of the vignette character.

Participants. A total of 46 participants did not provide usable answers for any of the dependent measures, and an additional 24 participants had missing data on at least one demographic variable and are thus not included in the analysis (final $N = 1,965$).⁷ Descriptive statistics of the Study 1 sample are in Table S4 in Part B of the online supplement. The Study 1 sample had 932 men and 1,033 women; their

ages ranged from 18 to 94 years (see the “other explanatory variables” section for details on the demographic measures).

Procedure. Participants were randomly assigned to read one of four vignettes about an individual’s dating history. The vignettes varied based on the target individual’s gender (man or woman) and their past dating history (exclusively heterosexual or gay/lesbian). A recent sexual encounter (a “casual sexual encounter” with a different-sex or same-sex partner) was always described as conflicting with the vignette individual’s past dating history (e.g., if only same-sex past, person would have a heterosexual encounter, or vice-versa). The following is a sample vignette; all italicized words varied by condition:⁸

Michael is currently single but has had multiple happy relationships with *women* in the past. *Michael* has only dated *women* and one of his relationships with a *woman* named *Emily* lasted for over two years. The other night, *Michael* met *Matt* and felt attracted to *him*. At the end of the night, *Michael* and *Matt* went home together and had a casual sexual encounter.

Because our goal is to test how even a minimal amount of presumed sexual contact can influence assumptions of sexual orientation, we describe the recent sexual encounter as a “casual sexual encounter.”⁹

Independent variables. Our independent variables come from the vignette conditions. Specifically, we included a categorical indicator variable for *vignette condition* with four categories: (1) man with a heterosexual dating history but recent same-sex encounter, (2) man with a gay dating history but recent different-sex encounter, (3) woman with a heterosexual dating history but recent same-sex encounter, and (4) woman with a gay dating history but recent different-sex encounter.

Dependent variables. Immediately after reading the vignette, participants were asked

how likely they thought the target character was *heterosexual*, *bisexual*, or *gay/lesbian*. All three sexual orientations were measured by asking participants to choose from 0 to 100 percent, thus assessing participants’ subjective certainty about the character’s sexual orientation. The instructions included the note “100 would indicate you are *completely certain* Michael is that orientation, while 0 would indicate you are *completely certain* Michael is *not* that orientation.”¹⁰ For analysis, we rescale the measures to range from 0 to 1 by dividing each response by 100. Therefore, the dependent variables can be interpreted as the probability that the participant thought the target character was that sexual orientation.¹¹

Participants were instructed to provide an answer for each sexual orientation. We chose this method to (1) assess the certainty of participants’ judgements and (2) examine their judgments of each orientation. If we had assessed judgments with a fixed-choice question (where participants choose one orientation they think is most likely), our analysis could treat individuals who are 51 percent certain (a toss-up) the character was one orientation equivalently to someone who was 100 percent certain. Additionally, some participants may be split between two orientations but be certain the vignette character is *not* one orientation; a fixed-choice question would be unable to uncover the participant’s thoughts on the second most likely orientation. Our design deals with both issues.

The distributions of our dependent measures are illustrated in Figures S4 through S9 in the online supplement. These figures provide histograms of the dependent variables separated by experimental condition.

Other explanatory variables. We also control for basic demographic factors that were provided by GfK in TESS’s standard delivery. These include measures of participants’ gender category with an indicator for *man*, *age* in years and *age*², *educational degree*, *race*, *household income*, whether they are *married*, if they live in a *metro area*, *region of the United States*, *political views*,

religious affiliation, and *religious attendance* (see Table S4 in the online supplement for our operationalization of each control variable).

Analytic Strategy

For all analyses, we report participants' percent certainty for the three sexual orientations we assessed: heterosexual, bisexual, and gay/lesbian. We use fractional response logistic regression because the outcomes are continuous measures bounded between zero and one, similar to a proportion or probability. In contrast to linear regression, fractional logistic regression does not assume that model residuals are homoscedastic, and it constrains predictions to be between zero and one. In sensitivity analyses, we found consistent evidence for our effects when using various robust strategies in the linear regression framework (see Part C of the online supplement).

We focus on model predictions and test for the contrasts of interest using post-estimation Wald tests. We include control variables for all measures described above. As expected due to random assignment to condition, the results are substantively identical in models with no control variables (see Mutz 2011). All tests are two-tailed with significance assessed at the $p < .05$ level unless otherwise noted.¹²

Results of Study 1

We begin by analyzing the vignettes describing an individual with a heterosexual dating history but a recent same-sex experience. The top panel of Table 1 shows the mean percent certainty for each orientation, separately for each experimental condition; the same information is summarized in Figures 2, 3, and 4.¹³ The bottom panel of Table 1 presents the regression results for the significance of the contrast between men and women vignette characters split by the character's relationship history as heterosexual or gay/lesbian.¹⁴

History of heterosexual relationships: recent same-sex experience. Hypothesis 1 predicts that men's heterosexuality will be

more easily questioned than women's heterosexuality after a single same-sex experience. We find support for this hypothesis, with men's heterosexuality appearing more precarious than women's heterosexuality. As Figure 2 illustrates, a heterosexual woman who has a same-sex experience is most likely to still be viewed as heterosexual, with participants reporting a 51 percent certainty that she is still heterosexual. In contrast, a heterosexual man in the same situation is still viewed as heterosexual with only 31 percent certainty (conditional difference = .205, $p < .001$). We also find that, after a single same-sex experience, men with heterosexual pasts are more likely to be seen as gay (24 percent certainty) than are previously heterosexual women to be seen as lesbian (15 percent certainty; conditional difference = .078, $p < .001$; see Figure 3).¹⁵ Figure 4 shows that previously heterosexual men are most likely to be seen as bisexual (51 percent certainty), which is greater than the probability that a woman in the same situation is viewed as bisexual (41 percent certainty; conditional difference = .101, $p < .001$). Overall, our findings strongly support our precarious heterosexuality hypothesis: after a single same-sex experience, heterosexual women are most likely to be viewed as still heterosexual, whereas men lose assumptions of heterosexuality and are more often seen as bisexual or gay.

History of gay/lesbian relationships: recent different-sex experience. Hypothesis 2 predicts that because of the particularly high status of men's heterosexuality, it will be difficult for individuals to enter the category who were not previously associated with it.

In support of our predictions, after a single different-sex encounter, men with same-sex dating histories are less often viewed as heterosexual (9 percent) than are women with a same-sex history (11 percent; conditional difference = .029, $p = .044$; see Figure 2). The contrast is statistically significant and in the direction predicted by Hypothesis 2, but it is worth noting that neither character is viewed as heterosexual at a particularly high rate.

Table 1. Means for Sexual Orientation Percent Guesses Based on Vignette Characteristics (Top Panel) and Fractional Response Logit Regression Results (Bottom Panel); Study 1 ($N = 1,965$)

	Percent Certainty That Target Character Is Listed Sexual Orientation		
	Heterosexual	Bisexual	Gay/Lesbian
Woman (Heterosexual Past)	51	41	15
Man (Heterosexual Past)	31	51	24
Woman (Lesbian Past)	11	54	40
Man (Gay Past)	9	51	47

	Fractional Response Logit Results		
	Heterosexual	Bisexual	Gay/Lesbian
Woman vs. Man (Heterosexual Past)	.205*** (.022)	-.101*** (.023)	-.078*** (.017)
Woman vs. Man (Lesbian/Gay Past)	.029* (.014)	.027 (.023)	-.068** (.023)

Note: Participants specified a percent guess for each sexual orientation from 0 to 100 percent. Standard errors are in parentheses. Effect sizes vary slightly in the regression models from presented raw sample means due to the addition of control variables.
* $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$; *** $p < .001$ (two-tailed tests).

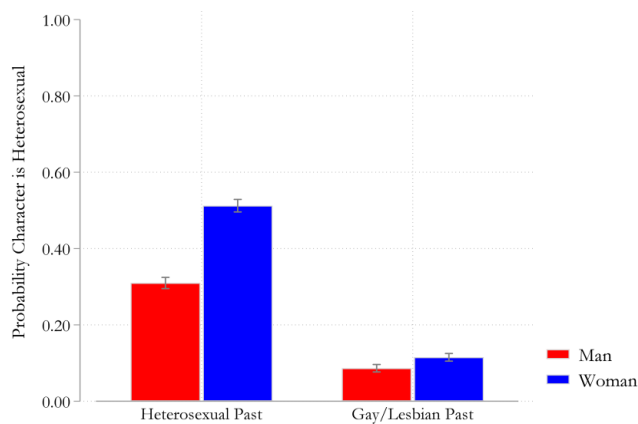


Figure 2. Probability Rating That Vignette Character Is Heterosexual, Study 1

We also find significant differences in perceptions of these characters as gay/lesbian based on the vignette character’s gender. As Figure 3 shows, men with same-sex histories are more likely to still be viewed as gay (47 percent) compared to women with same-sex histories still being viewed as lesbian (40 percent; conditional difference = .068, $p < .01$). There is no significant difference in

perceptions of the two characters as bisexual (difference = .027, $p = ns$).

Study 1 Summary

Using a nationally representative sample of the U.S. population, Study 1 provides strong support for our hypothesis that men’s heterosexuality is especially precarious. The results

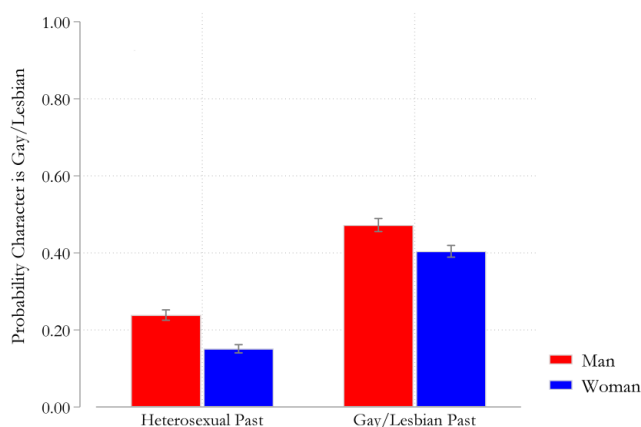


Figure 3. Probability Rating That Vignette Character Is Gay/Lesbian, Study 1

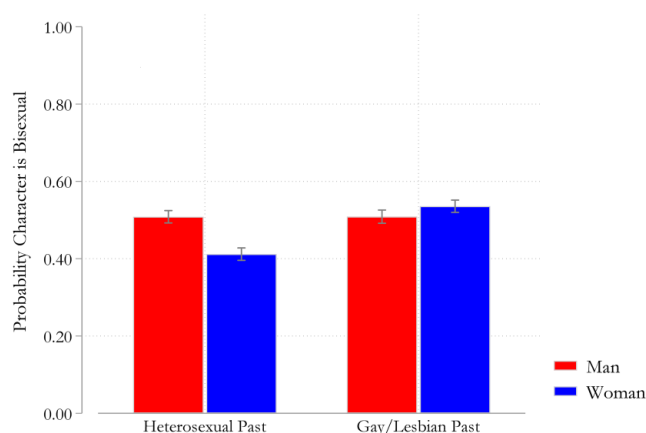


Figure 4. Probability Rating That Vignette Character Is Bisexual, Study 1

show that after a same-sex experience, men are more likely to be perceived as gay and bisexual, whereas women largely retain assumptions of heterosexuality. In addition, we found that men who would previously be classified as gay are less likely to be relabeled as heterosexual (allowed to enter the high-status category of men's heterosexuality) compared to women who would previously be classified as lesbian, supporting Hypothesis 2. We also found evidence that a lesbian woman's identity is more easily questioned than a gay man's identity, with previously gay men more likely to remain labeled as gay after a different-sex experience.

STUDIES 2A AND 2B

Study 1 provides strong support for the predictions of the precarious sexuality argument, but it cannot rule out alternative explanations for the precariousness effect not involving a status mechanism. One possibility is that men's heterosexuality appears more precarious because of different assumptions about men's versus women's same-sex sexual behavior. That is, individuals might assume different sexual behaviors when they consider two men "hooking up" or having a casual sexual encounter than when they consider two women doing the same. If so, our

findings might be due to individuals viewing some same-sex behaviors as more similar to traditional hegemonic notions of what “sex” is than other same-sex behaviors.¹⁶

Despite these possible differences in perceptions of same-sex behavior for men and women, the precarious sexuality argument suggests that men’s heterosexuality is more precarious than women’s heterosexuality, above and beyond differences in perceptions of behavior. That is, even if men and women are specifically described as participating in the same sexual behavior, men’s heterosexuality will still be more precarious than women’s because, as argued earlier, the effect is driven by preexisting differences in category status beliefs. To ascertain whether the findings in Study 1 were not due to participants assuming different sexual behaviors in same-sex sexual encounters between men and women, we designed two conceptual replications where we unambiguously described the sexual behavior of the vignette characters.

Study 2A describes the two vignette characters as going home together and “kissing passionately”; Study 2B describes the characters as having “oral sex.” Thus, if we detect any differences in perceptions of the vignette characters’ sexual orientation under these conditions, they will not be due to differences in perceptions of their sexual behavior. In addition, by varying the intimacy of the sexual encounter, we can assess how robust the precarious sexuality effect is from relatively minor sexual behavior (kissing, Study 2A) to more intimate behavior (oral sex, Study 2B; “casual sexual encounter,” Study 1).

Methods

Participants – Amazon Mechanical Turk (mTurk). We recruited participants from Amazon Mechanical Turk (mTurk) for Studies 2A and 2B to obtain a diverse sample of U.S. adults. mTurk is an online workplace platform that allows anyone with an Internet connection and an mTurk account to accept small “jobs.” There has been much recent interest in mTurk as a source for empirical

data, and researchers have found mTurk samples (1) produce results comparable to those using traditional subject pools (Paolacci, Chandler, and Iperiotis 2010), (2) replicate prominent historical psychology experiments (Rand 2012), and (3) replicate social science survey experiments conducted in nationally representative samples (Mullinix et al. 2015; Weinberg, Freese, and McElhattan 2014).

Our survey was open to all U.S. residents over age 18, with participants informed they could participate in a 10-minute survey in exchange for a cash payment. A total of 383 mTurk workers answered our survey. We removed two participants for failing attention checks, leaving us with a final sample of 381 participants for analysis (214 men, 167 women).¹⁷ We conducted Studies 2A and 2B at the same time to be able to compare results across studies if needed, but we randomly assigned participants to read and give answers about only one of the two scenarios ($N_{\text{Study-2A}} = 191$; $N_{\text{Study-2B}} = 190$).

Demographics of mTurk sample.

Although mTurk samples are not representative of all U.S. adults, they do provide a diverse national sample that has more generalizability than traditional experimental subject pools. Table S5 in Part B of the online supplement presents the demographics of our Study 2 sample along with comparable estimates of the U.S. population. Ages in our sample range from 19 to 78 years, with a mean age of 35. Our sample is less religious than most of the United States, more educated, and less conservative. The majority of our sample is white (81 percent).

Procedure and key measures. Studies 2A and 2B were identical in design to Study 1 except for differences in the final sentence of the vignette describing the sexual encounter. Study 1 used a vague description of the encounter, but Studies 2A and 2B used specific descriptions. In Study 2A, the vignette read that the two characters “went home together and kissed passionately”; in Study 2B, the end of the vignette read “went home

together and had oral sex.” The same four conditions were repeated for Studies 2A and 2B, with the vignette characters varying on their past dating history (exclusively heterosexual or exclusively gay/lesbian) and the gender of the other person involved in the recent sexual encounter. We again asked participants to assess how likely they thought the character was *heterosexual*, *gay/lesbian*, or *bisexual*, measured identically to Study 1 (see Methods section for Study 1).

Open-response item and content coding. In Studies 2A and 2B, we sought to better understand *why* men and women are categorized differently for the same sexual behavior. In addition to examining the nature of the sexual encounter, we wanted to investigate possible explanations for the vignette characters’ behavior that we had not considered. To do so, we asked an open-response item of all participants: “If you had to guess, why do you think *Emily/Michael* behaved the way *she/he* did in the story you just read?” This item was administered on a separate page from the vignette, immediately after participants had read the vignette and classified the character’s sexual orientation on our quantitative measures.

We had two research assistants content code all responses for common themes. To begin the coding process, the authors and the two research assistants read through all participant responses and collaboratively developed a list of common themes that emerged. The two research assistants were blind to the hypotheses, experimental condition of each response, and specific purpose of the study. To develop a succinct coding scheme, we led the research assistants through a series of discussions with the goal of clearly defining inclusion and exclusion criteria for codes. We took commonly occurring themes in the context of current gender and sexualities research. We developed codes by considering how common phrases or ideas aligned with each other and the literature. When we had disagreements or confusion, we facilitated a discussion during which small modifications to

the coding scheme were made. After careful consideration, we developed a final list of codes and instituted a set of guidelines to code the responses (we follow Compton, Love, and Sell [2012] for details on development of coding schemes; see Tables S6 and S7 in Part B of the online supplement for the detailed codes and guidelines we developed and used in our study).¹⁸

Next, the two research assistants carefully read and coded 50 percent of responses; we then examined inter-coder reliability, which was acceptable on all existing measures ($\geq .75$; Compton et al. 2012). We then modified the coding scheme slightly based on suggestions from the coders. Next, the coders recoded all the data using the final coding scheme. The final round of coding achieved acceptable inter-coder reliability for all codes that occurred in at least 5 percent of responses ($\geq .75$, simple agreement; for details on computing reliability, see Compton et al. 2012; see the first column of Table 4 for the reliability of each presented theme).¹⁹

Analytic Strategy

Our analytic strategy for the quantitative measures of sexual orientation is identical to Study 1. All models presented in the text include controls for the participant’s gender, age and age², race, political views, religiosity, religious affiliation, and educational attainment (see Table S5 in the online supplement for exact operationalizations of each measure). Sensitivity analyses with no control variables provide substantively equivalent results.

Results of Studies 2A and 2B

Our key finding that men’s heterosexuality is more precarious than women’s heterosexuality replicates in Studies 2A and 2B. However, the effect sizes and results for other contrasts diverge slightly with the more specific vignette descriptions. Table 2 shows the mean percent certainty for each sexual orientation based on the experimental condition (top panel) and the fractional logistic regression

Table 2. Means for Sexual Orientation Percent Guesses Based on Vignette Characteristics (Top Panel) and Fractional Response Logit Regression Results (Bottom Panel); Study 2A: Kissing Scenario ($N = 191$)

	Percent Certainty That Target Character Is Listed Sexual Orientation		
	Heterosexual	Bisexual	Gay/Lesbian
Woman (Heterosexual Past)	47	49	12
Man (Heterosexual Past)	34	51	28
Woman (Lesbian Past)	13	59	39
Man (Gay Past)	8	55	41
	Fractional Response Logit Results		
	Heterosexual	Bisexual	Gay/Lesbian
Woman vs. Man (Heterosexual Past)	.150* (.069)	-.015 (.067)	-.162** (.049)
Woman vs. Man (Lesbian/Gay Past)	.052 (.033)	.046 (.066)	-.036 (.064)

Note: Participants specified a percent guess for each sexual orientation from 0 to 100 percent. Standard errors are in parentheses. Effect sizes vary slightly in the regression models from presented raw sample means due to the addition of control variables.

* $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$; *** $p < .001$ (two-tailed tests).

results (bottom panel) for Study 2A (kissing scenario). Table 3 includes the same information for Study 2B (oral sex scenario).

History of heterosexual relationships: recent same-sex experience. In line with Hypothesis 1, previously heterosexual men were less likely to be labeled as heterosexual after a same-sex experience than were previously heterosexual women in the same situation. When the vignette characters were described as kissing someone of the same-sex, women (47 percent) were seen as heterosexual with greater certainty than were men (34 percent; conditional difference = .150, $p = .030$). Similarly, women were more likely than men to be seen as heterosexual after having oral sex with someone of the same-sex (46 versus 34 percent; conditional difference = .126, $p = .040$). These results provide further evidence that men's heterosexuality is more precarious than women's heterosexuality—a difference that is not explained by the sexual behavior of individuals in same-sex sexual encounters—providing further support for Hypothesis 1.

Previously heterosexual men were most often viewed as bisexual in both scenarios (see Tables 2 and 3). However, we found no differences between the men and women vignette characters in perceptions of bisexuality, regardless of the specified sexual behavior (both differences $p = ns$). In the kissing scenario, previously heterosexual men were more likely to be labeled as gay (28 percent) than were previously heterosexual women (12 percent; conditional difference = .162, $p < .01$). In the oral sex vignettes, there is a similar but smaller and marginally significant effect on the ratings of the characters as gay, with the previously heterosexual man (19 percent) more likely to be viewed as gay than the previously heterosexual woman (13 percent; conditional difference = .058; $p = .087$).

History of gay/lesbian relationships: recent different-sex experience. In Study 1, we found evidence that men's heterosexuality is also more policed in terms of who can enter the category (Hypothesis 2). In Studies 2A and 2B, our findings are in the expected

Table 3. Means for Sexual Orientation Percent Guesses Based on Vignette Characteristics (Top Panel) and Fractional Response Logit Regression Results (Bottom Panel); Study 2B: Oral Sex Scenario ($N = 190$)

	Percent Certainty That Target Character Is Listed Sexual Orientation		
	Heterosexual	Bisexual	Gay/Lesbian
Woman (Heterosexual Past)	46	53	13
Man (Heterosexual Past)	34	54	19
Woman (Lesbian Past)	13	62	41
Man (Gay Past)	9	54	46

	Fractional Response Logit Results		
	Heterosexual	Bisexual	Gay/Lesbian
Woman vs. Man (Heterosexual Past)	.126* (.061)	.009 (.064)	-.058† (.034)
Woman vs. Man (Lesbian/Gay Past)	.036 (.036)	.100 (.067)	-.070 (.064)

Note: Participants specified a percent guess for each sexual orientation from 0 to 100 percent. Standard errors are in parentheses. Effect sizes vary slightly in the regression models from presented raw sample means due to the addition of control variables.

† $p < .10$; * $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$; *** $p < .001$ (two-tailed tests).

direction based on Hypothesis 2 and the Study 1 findings, but they are not statistically significant. Specifically, in the kissing vignettes, the woman (13 percent) is more likely to be viewed as heterosexual than the man (8 percent; conditional difference = .052; $p = .111$). The effect is in the same direction—but smaller—for the oral sex vignette (conditional difference = .036; $p = .317$). It is worth noting that these effect sizes for Studies 2A and 2B are larger than those observed in Study 1, and thus differences in statistical power across the studies could be a reason for differing significance of the contrasts across studies. We interpret these findings as weak, but consistent, evidence for Hypothesis 2.

We found no differences in perceptions of the previously gay/lesbian vignette characters as bisexual in Study 2A or 2B (consistent with Study 1). In Study 1, gay men's gay identity was more immutable than lesbian women's identity. In contrast, in Studies 2A and 2B we find no significant differences in perceptions of the characters as gay/lesbian (both differences $p = ns$).

Summary of Studies 2A and 2B

Studies 2A and 2B suggest that differences in the precariousness of men's and women's heterosexuality are not due to differences in perceptions of sexual behavior between same-sex relationships. In vignette situations that unambiguously described the sexual behavior of the individuals involved—which allowed us to control for differences in individuals' perceptions of what a "sexual encounter" is—we again found that men's heterosexuality is more precarious than women's heterosexuality.

Supplementary Analysis

Open-ended explanation of vignette characters' behavior. In addition to the quantitative analyses described earlier, we also included a single open-ended question in Studies 2A and 2B that asked participants to speculate why the vignette characters behaved the way they did. We included this measure to help determine why participants were categorizing the vignette character as they were and

to assess the possibility of alternative explanations. We then content coded the responses for common themes and analyzed whether certain themes were more or less prevalent in different experimental conditions (see the Study 2 Methods section for details).

To determine whether certain themes were more likely to be invoked as an explanation for men's or women's behavior, we analyze the prevalence of each theme across experimental conditions. Table 4 presents the proportion of total responses that mentioned each theme, separately for each experimental condition. Due to our relatively small sample size and the infrequency of some of the themes, we combined the responses from Studies 2A and 2B into a single analysis.²⁰ We test for significant differences in the prevalence of a certain theme using a Pearson's chi-square test of association.²¹ For example, the first row of Table 4 presents the proportion of participants stating that physical/sexual attraction was the reason for the vignette character's behavior when the target character was a woman with a heterosexual past (column 1) or a man with a heterosexual past (column 2); Column 3 shows the chi-square statistic for the test of differences between these two proportions.

Open-response results. The most common explanation given for the vignette characters' behavior was that they felt physically or sexually attracted to the other person; the proportion of participants offering this explanation did not differ when the target character was a man or a woman. Another common explanation was that sexuality is not a binary concept, and thus it was natural for the character to be interested in both men and women. Three less common explanations also did not vary based on the vignette character's gender: behavior motivated by an emotional connection, by sexual impulsivity or promiscuity, and due to alcohol use.

Some explanations did vary, however, based on the gender of the vignette character. For example, a relatively large proportion of participants explained the vignette character's behavior as experimentation or acting out of

curiosity. However, this explanation was invoked more commonly when the vignette character was a woman: 33 percent of participants offered experimentation/curiosity as an explanation for a previously heterosexual woman having a sexual encounter with another woman. For example, one participant said that "she was curious and wanted to try something different," and another suggested "she was bored and wanted to try something she has never done before." In contrast, only 23 percent of participants offered the experimentation/curiosity explanation for a man in a similar situation ($\chi^2 = 4.97, p < .05$). Similarly, participants were more likely to attribute the behavior of a woman with a lesbian dating history to experimentation (18 percent), compared to a man with a gay dating history (11 percent, $\chi^2 = 3.77, p = .05$).

Some participants described the characters' behavior as representing their "true" self or sexuality; that is, the characters were really heterosexual or gay/lesbian all along and their recent sexual encounter represents their "true" orientation. The frequency of this explanation varied based on the vignette character's gender: women with a heterosexual dating history were described as finding their true self/sexuality only 6 percent of the time after a same-sex encounter; previously heterosexual men, in contrast, were described as finding their true self/sexuality 19 percent of the time after a same-sex encounter ($\chi^2 = 13.44, p < .001$). For example, one participant proposed "maybe his homosexual feelings have just been repressed until now" and another stated "he was probably always gay."²²

Taken together, the open-ended responses further suggest that women's sexuality is viewed as more fluid and open to experimentation, whereas men's heterosexuality is most heavily policed, with rigid boundaries establishing acceptable behavior for someone who belongs to the category. Participants' answers suggest that women are given more freedom to experiment with their sexuality, that is, women can be heterosexual but still experiment with other groups. In contrast, sexual experimentation is less compatible with ideas

Table 4. Prevalence and (Reliabilities) for Themes From Open-Ended Responses Asking Why Vignette Character Had a Recent Sexual Encounter (Studies 2A and 2B)

		Woman Heterosexual Past (%)	Man Heterosexual Past (%)	χ^2	Woman Lesbian Past (%)	Man Gay Past (%)	χ^2
Physical / sexual attraction	(.88)	37	32	.87	36	36	<.01
Sexuality is non-binary	(.92)	21	16	1.88	32	32	<.01
Curiosity / experimentation	(.96)	33	23	4.97*	18	11	3.77†
Emotional connection	(.89)	7	7	.05	9	12	.81
Sexual impulsivity/promiscuity	(.94)	11	8	.85	9	7	.77
Discovered true sexuality/self	(.96)	6	19	13.44***	3	0	4.96*
Alcohol	(1.00)	7	4	1.8	5	4	.19

Note: Inter-coder reliabilities for each theme are included in parentheses in the first column. Prevalence of responses are reported as a percentage (proportion of participants' answers that mentioned that theme). The chi-square column reports the test statistic comparing the previous two columns.

† $p < .10$; * $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$; *** $p < .001$ (two-tailed tests).

about men's heterosexuality—men who have some same-sex contact are often described as discovering some “true” latent non-heterosexual sexuality.

DISCUSSION AND CONCLUSIONS

How are men and women assessed differently for the same sexual behavior? We proposed that men's heterosexuality is a precarious sexuality due to its uniquely advantaged status position; this leads to policing the boundaries of acceptable behavior to maintain the current social hierarchy with men's heterosexuality most advantaged. Because of the advantaged status of men's heterosexuality, and the associated strict boundaries, we suggested that men and women would be categorized differently after having a single same-sex sexual encounter.

As predicted, we found that men's heterosexuality is especially precarious and easily lost, with even minor same-sex sexual encounters leading men to no longer remain in the category of “heterosexual man” in the eyes of observers (supporting Hypothesis 1). Because

women's heterosexuality is less advantaged—and because there is less status differentiation among women's sexual orientation categories—people appear to be more lenient when determining what is acceptable behavior to remain in the category “heterosexual woman.” Specifically, we showed that a single same-sex experience has a much smaller effect on perceptions of women's heterosexuality than it does on perceptions of men's heterosexuality. Women predominantly retain assumptions of heterosexuality, whereas men are most often relabeled as gay or bisexual after a single same-sex experience. Categorization into sexual minority groups has important consequences, because sexual minorities are viewed less positively than heterosexual individuals and face discrimination across many domains (Herek and McLemore 2013; Mishel 2016; Mize and Manago forthcoming; Tilcsik 2011). Our findings show that heterosexual men, in particular, are always on the edge of losing their membership in the privileged group, and they are labeled as gay or bisexual with even minimal same-sex contact.

In addition to investigating how category-inconsistent behavior influences who can *stay*

in the high-status category of men's heterosexuality, we further examined if status processes influence who is allowed to *enter* the category. In partial support of Hypothesis 2, in Study 1 we found that among vignette characters who had same-sex dating histories, women were more likely to be relabeled as heterosexual compared to men.²³ We attribute this finding to a further protection process of the high status of men's heterosexuality: by barring a man previously considered to be "gay" from entering the high-status category of men's heterosexuality, the high-status designation itself is preserved.

Our analysis of precarious sexuality highlights the status dynamics integral to categorization processes. We proposed that men's heterosexuality would be especially precarious because it is a uniquely privileged category, and because there is clear status differentiation among sexual orientation categories for men. We drew on previous findings regarding other social categories, suggesting that processes that make racial and gender categories precarious should similarly apply to sexual orientation. In regard to race, previous research in the United States has demonstrated the "one drop rule," which sets strict guidelines for who can claim an advantageous white identity; individuals with even "one drop" of non-white ancestry are viewed as a minority and thus not afforded the privileges of being white. Similarly, masculinity—the privileged and advantaged state of gender—has a precarious nature, with men having to constantly strive to maintain their masculine identity.

Our ideas about the precariousness of social categories based on their status value could apply broadly outside of race, gender, and sexual orientation. Theoretically, it is reasonable to expect that any social category that (1) carries a high amount of status value, (2) is broadly considered and known to carry advantages, and (3) is clearly differentiated from other relevant categories in terms of status value should have heavily policed boundaries, and membership in the category will be precarious and easily lost.²⁴ Future research could examine other social

categories to provide evidence for or against this broader theoretical proposition.

For instance, social category distinctions could be created experimentally and then challenged, allowing for causal tests of precariousness effects for emergent categories, separate from the social connotations that accompany status categories (e.g., racial categories have status value but also many other connotations). Similar theoretical tests have been used to show how status beliefs develop (e.g., Ridgeway et al. 1998; Ridgeway et al. 2009), and a similar abstract test of our theoretical ideas could profitably enhance our understanding of how general status processes influence categorization.

On the whole, our findings do not support the counterargument of high-status leniency, that is, the idea that actors from high-status groups are judged more leniently than actors from lower-status groups. If this were the case, heterosexual men would be judged least harshly for category-inconsistent behavior. Future work is needed to more precisely adjudicate between precarious status and high-status leniency processes. We suggest that differences between processes of evaluation and categorization are most likely responsible for these seemingly conflicting predictions. That is, we do not necessarily read our results as countering the high-status leniency argument for evaluations; instead, we would interpret them more stringently as not supporting high-status leniency when applied to categorization. We would still expect high-status actors to be judged more leniently if the judgment of interest was about competence or capability rather than social categorization itself (see, e.g., Foschi 2000). Future studies could profitably explore this distinction to investigate under which situations high-status designations lead to lenient treatment rather than strict policing.

In Studies 2A and 2B, we assessed whether different assumptions about the kind of sexual behavior that occurs between men and women in same-sex relationships could account for the patterns shown in Study 1. That is, individuals might categorize men who have

same-sex sexual relations differently from similar women, because they assume two men engage in different kinds of sexual behavior than two women. Hegemonic conceptions of sex and intimacy could influence judgments of individuals in same-sex relationships. However, as the studies showed, when the sexual behavior of men or women in same-sex relationships is described unambiguously to observers—thus removing room for interpretation or imagination—men’s heterosexuality is still seen as more precarious than women’s heterosexuality. It is worth noting that our effect sizes in Studies 2A and 2B were smaller than those from Study 1, which might suggest that *some* of the precariousness of men’s heterosexuality is due to presumed sexual behavior—however, this does not completely account for the effect, with men’s heterosexuality seen as more precarious regardless of the sexual behavior described. Therefore, we suggest that the differential categorization of men and women who engage in similar sexual behavior is primarily a result of hierarchies of sexual orientation and gender and concomitant norms about behavior—which make highly valued statuses (e.g., men’s heterosexuality) precarious.

Our findings illustrate the importance of considering gender and sexuality intersectionally. For example, the category of heterosexual is viewed more favorably in society compared to gay, lesbian, and bisexual, and it might have higher status value than other sexual orientations when considered in the abstract. However, when considered intersectionally with gender, it becomes clear that the status value of heterosexuality cannot be determined without concomitant considerations of gender; that is, the categories of heterosexual men and heterosexual women have distinctly different status values (for a similar argument, see Johnson 1995).

Furthermore, gender and sexuality operate intersectionally beyond status processes: the types of sexual behavior that satisfy societal expectations of masculinity and femininity differ for men and women. Expectations for men’s heterosexuality—the only sexual

orientation category for men that satisfies hegemonic masculine expectations—demand only different-sex behavior and mandate being attracted to women. In contrast, women’s femininity is more closely tied to being attractive to men. Because same-sex behavior among women can be seen as attractive to men, this behavior does not necessarily undermine assumptions of women’s femininity or their heterosexuality.

Future work could take an even more intersectional approach to determine how factors such as race and age influence sexual orientation categorization. Stereotypes of sexuality and gender vary for different racial groups in the United States, thus categorization might differ for individuals from different racial groups who exhibit the same behavior (Gamson and Moon 2004; Pedulla 2014). Because men’s heterosexuality is the most advantaged sexual orientation category within each racial group, we suspect it would be precarious across racial categories. However, future tests could verify this proposition and examine whether the extent of precariousness varies by race. Age also likely influences sexual orientation categorization. For example, young women’s sexuality is stereotyped as relatively fluid, thus we would expect a single sexual encounter to have less influence on observers’ perceptions of sexual orientation while a woman is young (i.e., early 20s) than when a woman is older (Diamond 2003; Peplau 2003).

An important question we do not directly address here is *why* people police high-status categories—in particular, why individuals who are not a part of that high-status group might also police category membership. Many stereotypes of social groups and status beliefs exist at a consensual level. That is, many beliefs, such as the belief that men are generally more competent and able than women, exist at a cultural level and broadly influence perceptions and behavior across social locations—regardless of whether someone personally endorses these beliefs (Ridgeway and Correll 2004).²⁵ Future work could examine the relationship between

cultural consensus around sexual orientation categorization and categorization of other high-status designations.

In addition, although it seems intuitive that most individuals would strive for high-status designations themselves, work suggests there are penalties for lower-status individuals who attempt to claim high-status designations—and lower-status individuals gain some social advantages by “knowing their place” and preserving existing status hierarchies (Anderson et al. 2006; Ridgeway and Nakagawa 2017). Thus, individuals from lower-status groups may act in ways that police and preserve high-status designations, because there is normative and social pressure (and some social benefit) to act in accordance with existing status hierarchies.

Other types of beliefs, however, can be reinforced or strengthened specifically by the most powerful members of society. For example, advantaged groups, such as white individuals or masculine men, have strong motivations to set strict boundaries, guidelines, and rules for what constitutes membership in the advantaged group. Because these groups tend to monopolize power and access to authority positions, they have the ability to set cultural expectations and boundaries for membership in these categories. Thus, we might expect advantaged groups to be most likely to, or to most stringently, police membership in those categories.

Yet another possibility is that all individuals are hesitant to grant others high-status designations, and when there is doubt about an actor's category membership, people take the opportunity to categorize someone as lower status. This strategy, for all individuals—regardless of their status position—could be beneficial: the actor who was previously in a high-status position loses status, effectively either eliminating a competitor for status positioning (e.g., for a heterosexual male observer) or bringing someone down to an equivalent level (e.g., for a gay male observer). Future studies could consider how observers' social location influences their categorization decisions. Such

work could help determine why different social groups police membership in high-status categories.

Finally, this article focuses only on categorization processes, but there are likely additional important implications of sexual behavior and identity ascriptions. In particular, sexual minorities face disadvantages partially due to stigmatization of their identity. We suspect that in addition to men and women facing different categorization assumptions based on their sexual behavior, they will also be differentially stigmatized. Status and stigma processes share considerable conceptual and empirical overlaps, with low-status groups also more likely to be stigmatized (Hipes, Lucas, and Kleykamp 2015; Lucas and Phelan 2012). Consistent with the idea that status and stigma tend to co-vary, in exploratory analyses we found that not only are heterosexual men stripped of assumptions of heterosexuality more quickly than are heterosexual women, but they are also more stigmatized for that behavior.²⁶ Future work focusing on the stigmatization consequences of sexual behavior would help substantiate the importance of the categorization processes outlined here.

In summary, in this article we examine how individuals apply sexual orientation labels to others, revealing an asymmetry in the consequences of same-sex behavior for men and women. Compared to women, men who exhibit even minimal non-heterosexual behavior are relabeled from heterosexual to bisexual or gay, removing them from an advantageous social group. The precariousness of men's heterosexuality is rooted in status-differentiated society, where some groups have more resources, privilege, and power than others. Sexual orientation—like other social categories—is stratified, with some groups subordinated while others benefit. A counter-intuitive consequence of this stratification is that advantaged groups occupy a precarious position, with any category-inconsistent behavior threatening that entire group's advantaged status, producing narrow boundaries for acceptable behavior for members of these privileged groups.

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Notes

1. We use the term “sexual minorities” to refer to anyone whose sexual orientation would not be classified as heterosexual.
2. In this article, we focus on the sexual orientation categories of heterosexual, gay/lesbian, and bisexual. We do not intend to suggest these are the only sexual orientation categories, or that these categories are real or natural; rather, we recognize that sexual orientation categories are socially constructed and that the boundaries of the categories vary over time and place. At this time in U.S. society, we suggest that heterosexual, gay/lesbian, and bisexual are the three predominantly recognized and understood categories; therefore, they are the three categories about which beliefs about gender and status are likely to be known, thus influencing the categorization processes we examine here.
3. On point one, see Podolny and Phillips (1996) and Fiske and colleagues (2002).
4. Mize and Manago (forthcoming) measure social status using Fiske and colleagues’ (2002) scale of general perceptions of a group’s overall social status.
5. In the case of law firms that Phillips and Zuckerman (2001) examine, adopting family law does not threaten a high-status firm’s position, whereas the “more deeply discrediting” personal injury law does threaten a firm’s position.
6. Before conducting what we refer to as “Study 1,” we first conducted a pilot study on a convenience sample of undergraduate students and then two pretest studies on Amazon Mechanical Turk. These were fielded to test our survey instrument, vignette design, and experimental manipulations. The findings from the pilot study and pretests further support the robustness of our theorized precarious heterosexuality effect. See Part A of the online supplement for a detailed description of these studies and their results.
7. Specifically, 22 respondents refused all the questions on the survey and 24 answered “0 percent” to all the dependent measures.
8. We chose popular white American baby names from the mid-1980s to minimize the number of characteristics present in the vignette: Michael, Matt, Emily, and Jennifer.
9. In our pilot study, we used the term “hook-up” because this is a commonly used term among younger cohorts that refers to any casual sexual encounter that takes place outside of a romantic relationship (Holman and Sillars 2012). However, to ensure that the diverse nationally representative sample understood our intent, we changed the language to “casual sexual encounter” for Study 1. We pretested both wordings in an online sample to ensure the nature of the vignette remained unchanged (Amazon mTurk sample $N = 108$). Describing the encounter as “hooked up” led to statistically equivalent responses about the vignette character’s sexual orientation as describing the encounter as “a casual sexual encounter,” as we intended (half of the pretest sample received each wording; differences for all three dependent measures were $p > .10$). See Part A of the online supplement for more detail on the pretest.
10. The text used the name “Emily” for vignettes where the target character was a woman.
11. In sensitivity analyses, we rescaled the dependent variables so that all three answers totaled 100 percent. The results are substantively identical. We present the raw responses in the text because answers totaling more than 100 percent are substantively valid. For example, a participant who is completely evenly split between the three orientations might believe there is a “50/50” chance for each, which would make their three answers total 150.
12. The data and coding files necessary to reproduce all the analyses presented in this article are available on the first author’s website at <http://trentonmize.com/research>.
13. All figures include error bars that represent ± 1 standard error of the estimate.
14. We present tests of differences in the predictions, because these are in the natural and measured metric of the dependent variable. The coefficients (e^{β} = odds ratios) provide identical conclusions but are more difficult to interpret directly.
15. We use the language “previously heterosexual” to simplify interpretations in the text. Specifically, this refers to vignette characters’ past dating history, because the vignette contained no information about characters’ declared identity.
16. We are not asserting these perceptions are accurate or reifying these differences as real or meaningful; rather, we are considering how the average person might view the situation and what influence that might have on their subsequent categorization of sexual orientation.
17. Results are substantively identical when including these two participants.
18. Each response could represent multiple themes/codes or none at all; each theme was allowed to be coded only once per response.
19. Some themes incorporated on the basis of previous literature were present in less than 5 percent

- of responses and thus rarely achieved our target reliability. Therefore, we did not analyze or report codes that appeared in less than 5 percent of responses. All codes that appeared in over 5 percent of responses achieved our target reliability.
20. For all significant effects described here, the patterns are substantively similar when analyzing the two studies separately, although significance varies due to the limited sample size and statistical power when analyzing the studies separately.
 21. All chi-square tests are performed on 2 x 2 tables with one degree of freedom.
 22. We found the opposite pattern for individuals with a gay/lesbian dating history, although an explanation of finding one's true self/sexuality was rare in both of these conditions, so the finding should be interpreted with caution. Women with lesbian dating histories were described as finding their true self/sexuality 3 percent of the time; this explanation was never offered (0 percent) for men with gay dating histories ($\chi^2 = 4.96, p < .05$).
 23. The effect sizes for this finding across the three studies are relatively small (and not statistically significant in Studies 2A and 2B), but we do find consistent evidence across all three vignette scenarios. Future work should further verify this finding, as it has weaker support than our key precarious men's heterosexuality effect (i.e., Hypothesis 1).
 24. Here, it is important to remind readers of our scope condition that this categorization process is limited to plausible alternative identities (see "A General Framework for Precarious Statuses" section).
 25. It is important to note that these general beliefs exist absent actual evidence of differences in competence and capability between groups.
 26. Our exploratory measures examined both desired social distance from the vignette character and morality assessments. For both measures, men with heterosexual romantic histories were more stigmatized for same-sex behavior than were women in the same situation (see Table S8 in Part B of the online supplement).

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